

LESSON 4

Personalizing the Text: Suffixes and Possession

SECTION 1: REVIEW OF LESSON 3

Quick Summary

In Lesson 3, we examined the Peal Perfect tense (the suffix conjugation), learning how Syriac describes completed, past actions. The sentence structure shifted from fluidly subject-led (in the present participle) to stringently Verb-Subject-Object (VSO) led narrative chains using the conjunction **w-** (and).

5-Question Warm-Up Drill

(Answers in Section 9)

1. What does the suffix **-ū** indicate on a Perfect verb (e.g., *ktabū*)?
2. Translate the basic VSO sentence: *Shbaq malkā l- 'ar 'ā*.
3. What happens to the pronunciation of *k-t-b* (ka-tab) in the Syriac 3rd m.sg Perfect?
4. How do you distinguish between “I went” and “You (m) went” if both are written ܬܬܒܬ (*ktabt/ketbet*) without vowels?
5. Translate: *w-qreb Yūḥannan*.

SECTION 2: POSSESSION AND PRONOMINAL SUFFIXES — OVERVIEW

In English, we indicate possession using separate pronouns placed before a noun: “my house”, “your king”. In Greek, it’s often an independent genitive pronoun: ὁ οἶκός μου (*ho oikos mou*).

However, in Semitic languages, possession is expressed by attaching a **pronominal suffix** directly to the end of the noun.

Cross-Linguistic Comparison: The Possessive Suffix

- **Hebrew:** סוס (*sūs*, horse) → סוסי (*sūsī*, my horse). אב (*'āb*, father) → אביו (*'ābīnū*, our father).
- **Arabic:** كتاب (*kitāb*, book) → كتابي (*kitābī*, my book).
- **Syriac:** ܬܬܒܬ (*ktāb*, book) → ܬܬܒܝ (*ktāby*, my book). ܐܒ (*'ab*, father) → ܐܒܝ (*'abūn*, our father).

These suffixes are derived from the same ancient roots as the independent pronouns (*ʿenā*, *ʿant*, *hū*) but are highly compressed.

SECTION 3: PRONOMINAL SUFFIXES ON NOUNS & PREPOSITIONS

1. Suffixes on Singular Nouns

To add a suffix, Syriac uses the Absolute state of the noun, not the Emphatic state. (You don't say "the my-king" **malkā-y* ; you say "king-my", *malk-y*).

- *Malk-* (king) + *-eh* (his) = *malkeh* (his king).
- *ʿAb-* (father) + *-y* (my) = *ʿaby* (my father).

2. Suffixes on Prepositions

The exact same suffixes attach to the inseparable prepositions *b-* (in) and *l-* (to/for).

- *b-* + *-eh* = *beh* (in him / in it).
- *l-* + *-k* = *lāk* (to you, m.sg).

3. The Idiom for "To Have"

Syriac (like Hebrew and Arabic) lacks a dedicated verb meaning "to possess" (like English "to have" or Latin "habere"). Instead, Semitic languages use a prepositional phrase: "there is to me" or just "to me".

- *īt l-y* (there-is to-me) → *ītly* = I have.
 - *layt l-eh* (there-is-not to-him) = He does not have.
 - *ītly srārā* = I have truth. (Lit: There is to me truth).
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SECTION 4: THE SUFFIX PARADIGM FOR SINGULAR NOUNS

This paradigm uses the masculine noun *malk-* (king, root m-l-k) and the feminine noun *malkūtt-* (kingdom). Notice the suffix column; you must memorize these endings.

PERSON	SUFFIX	MASCULINE NOUN (MALK-)	TRANSLIT	FEM NOUN (MALKŪTT-)	TRANSLIT
1 c.sg. (my)	-y (-y)	مالك	malk-y	مملكة	malkūtt-y
2 m.sg. (your)	-k (-k)	مالك	malk-āk	مملكة	malkūtt-āk
2 f.sg. (your)	-ky (-ky)	مالك	malk-ēky	مملكة	malkūtt-ēky
3 m.sg. (his)	-eh (-eh)	مالك	malk-eh	مملكة	malkūtt-eh
3 f.sg. (her)	-āh (-āh)	مالك	malk-āh	مملكة	malkūtt-āh
1 c.pl. (our)	-n (-n)	مالك	malk-an	مملكة	malkūtt-an
2 m.pl. (your)	-kūn (-kūn)	مالك	malk-kūn	مملكة	malkūtt-kūn
2 f.pl. (your)	-kēn (-kēn)	مالك	malk-kēn	مملكة	malkūtt-kēn
3 m.pl. (their)	-hūn (-hūn)	مالك	malk-hūn	مملكة	malkūtt-hūn
3 f.pl. (their)	-hēn (-hēn)	مالك	malk-hēn	مملكة	malkūtt-hēn

Orthography Note: The 3rd masculine singular (-eh) and 3rd feminine singular (-āh) are both spelled with a final Heh (ه). Only vowel pointing or context distinguishes “his” from “her”.

SECTION 5: PREPOSITIONAL "TO HAVE" PARADIGM (L- + SUFFIX)

How to say "I have", "You have", "He has", etc., by attaching suffixes to the **l-** preposition, often preceded by *it* (there is).

PERSON	ESTRANGELA (L- + SUFFIX)	TRANSLITERATION	MEANING
1 c.sg.	ل	lī	to me (I have)
2 m.sg.	لك	lāk	to you (You have)
2 f.sg.	لكي	lēky	to you (You have)
3 m.sg.	له	lēh	to him (He has)
3 f.sg.	له	lāh	to her (She has)
1 c.pl.	لنا	lān	to us (We have)
2 m.pl.	لكم	lkūn	to you (You all have)
3 m.pl.	لهم	lhūn	to them (They have)

SECTION 6: VOCABULARY (FAMILY, BODY PARTS & BELONGINGS)

Family and body parts are the most common nouns to receive pronominal suffixes.

ABSOLUTE / EMPHATIC	TRANSLITERATION	MEANING	EXAMPLE WITH SUFFIX (1 C.SG.)
אב / אבא	'ab / 'abā	Father	'ab-y (my father)
אמ / אמא	'em / 'emmā	Mother	'em-y (my mother)
בר / ברא	bar / brā	Son	bar-y (my son)
בת / בראתא	bart / brattā	Daughter	bart-y (my daughter)
אח / אחא	'ah / 'ahā	Brother	'ah-y (my brother)
יד / ידא	'id / 'idā	Hand (f)	'id-y (my hand)
ראש / ראשא	rēš / rēšā	Head (m)	rēš-y (my head)
קול / קולא	qāl / qālā	Voice (m)	qāl-y (my voice)
לבוש / לבושא	lbūš / lbūšā	Garment	lbūš-y (my garment)
בית / ביתא	bēt / baytā	House	bayt-y (my house)
מא / מאא	mā / mānā	What?	(Interrogative pronoun)
איך	'aykō	Where?	(Interrogative adverb)

SECTION 7: THE STORY – PART 4

A Dialogue at the Gate

*Narrative note: Watch how the guards use suffixes with prepositions (*lēh* , *lḵūn*) and nouns (*'abūk* , *'emāk*) to interrogate Yūḥannan about his origins and possessions.*

Sentence 1

קאם יוֹהָנָן בִּתְרֵא דְמַלְכֻּטָּא. qām Yūḥannan b-tar 'ā d-malküttā. qām (stood) Yūḥannan (John) b-tar 'ā (in-the-gate) d-malküttā (of-the-kingdom). → Yūḥannan stood at the gate of the kingdom.

Sentence 2

וְאֵלֵּי הַשָּׁרֵפִים וְאֵלֵּי הַשָּׂרֵפִים w- 'āmrīn qašīšē d-tar 'ā l-ēh: w- 'āmrīn (and-are-saying) qašīšē (the-elders/guards) d-tar 'ā (of-the-gate) l-ēh (to-him): → And the guards of the gate say to him:

Sentence 3

מֵאֵי מְדִינָה אַתָּה מֵאֵי מְדִינָה men 'aynā 'atrā 'ant? men (from) 'aynā (what) 'atrā (country/place) 'ant (you-[are])? → “From what country are you?”

Sentence 4

וְאֵי מְדִינָה אַתָּה אִי אֲבִיךָ וְאֵי מְדִינָה אַתָּה אִי אִמְךָ w- 'aykō 'ab-ūk w- 'em-āk? w- 'aykō (and-where) 'ab-ūk (father-your) w- 'em-āk (and-mother-your)? → “And where is your father and your mother?”

Sentence 5

וְאֵי מְדִינָה אַתָּה אִי אֲבִיךָ וְאֵי מְדִינָה אַתָּה אִי אִמְךָ w-mā it lāk b- 'īd-āk? w-mā (and-what) it (there-is) lāk (to-you) b- 'īd-āk (in-hand-your)? → “And what do you have in your hand?”

Sentence 6

וְאֵי מְדִינָה אַתָּה אִי אֲבִיךָ וְאֵי מְדִינָה אַתָּה אִי אִמְךָ emar l-hūn Yūḥannan: 'emar (said) l-hūn (to-them) Yūḥannan (John): → Yukhannan said to them:

Sentence 7

וְאֵי מְדִינָה אַתָּה אִי אֲבִיךָ וְאֵי מְדִינָה אַתָּה אִי אִמְךָ Alāhā hū 'ab-y, w- 'ar 'ā hī 'em-y. Alāhā (God) hū (he-[is]) 'ab-y (father-my), w- 'ar 'ā (and-the-earth) hī (she-[is]) 'em-y (mother-my). → “God is my father, and the earth is my mother.”

Sentence 8

וְאֵי מְדִינָה אַתָּה אִי אֲבִיךָ וְאֵי מְדִינָה אַתָּה אִי אִמְךָ w-layt lī lbūšā bīšā. w-layt (and-there-is-not) lī (to-me) lbūšā (a-garment) bīšā (evil). → “And I do not have an evil garment.”

Sentence 9

וְאֵי מְדִינָה אַתָּה אִי אֲבִיךָ וְאֵי מְדִינָה אַתָּה אִי אִמְךָ nūhrā d-Alāhā it-awhy b- 'īd-y. nūhrā (the-light) d-Alāhā (of-God) it-awhy (it-is) b- 'īd-y (in-hand-my). → “The light of God is in my hand.”

SECTION 8: EXERCISES

Exercise 1: Suffix Identification

Identify the person, gender, and number of the possessor for the following suffixed nouns.

1. ܡܠܟܐ (malk-an)
2. ܒܝܬܐ (bayt-eh)
3. ܝܕܝܗܝܬܐ (ʾīd-ēky)
4. ܡܠܟܘܬܗܘܢ (malkūt-hūn)

Exercise 2: Conjugation Drill (Possession)

Translate the following phrases using ܝܬ- + suffix (using *īt* where appropriate to mean “have”):

1. To you (f.sg).
2. We have (There is to us).
3. He does not have (There is not to him).
4. To them (m.pl).

Exercise 3: Translation Drill (Syriac → English)

Translate the following sentences containing suffixed nouns.

1. ʾAbī ṭābā hū, w-ʾemī ṭābtā hī.
2. Šbaqū talmīdē l-baythūn.
3. Īt lān nūhrā rabbā.
4. Qālā d-malkā b-ʾarʿan (ʾarʿ-an).

Exercise 4: Production Drill (English → Syriac)

Render the following sentences into Syriac transliteration.

1. My brother is writing a word.
2. The king and his son are going to his kingdom.
3. What is in your (m.sg) hand?
4. We do not have (*layt lān*) an evil king.

Exercise 5: Reading Comprehension

Re-read Section 7 and answer:

1. Under what three topics does the guard interrogate Yukhannan?
 2. Who does Yukhannan claim as his parents?
 3. What does Yukhannan explicitly state he *does not* have?
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SECTION 9: ANSWER KEY

Section 1 Warm-Up

1. 3rd person masculine plural (“they”).
2. The king left the earth.
3. The *a* vowel in the middle of the root disappears (vowel reduction), making it *ktab* (k-t-a-b).
4. Only context or vowel pointing.
5. And Yukhannan drew near.

Exercise 1: Suffix Identification

1. 1st common plural (Our king)
2. 3rd masc singular (His house)
3. 2nd fem singular (Your hand)
4. 3rd masc plural (Their kingdom)

Exercise 2: Conjugation Drill

1. lēky
2. īt lān
3. layt lēh
4. lhūn

Exercise 3: Translation Drill

1. My father is good, and my mother is good.
2. The disciples left their house (*bayt-hūn*).
3. We have a great light (There is to us a great light).
4. The voice of the king is in our land (‘ar ‘-an = ‘ar ‘ā + -an).

Exercise 4: Production Drill

1. ' aḥ-y kāteb meltā.
2. Malkā w-bar-eh ' āzlin l-malkūt-eh.
3. Mā it b- ' id-āk?
4. Layt lān malkā bīšā.

Exercise 5: Reading Comprehension

1. Origin (what country), Family (where are father/mother), and Possessions (what is in hand).
 2. God (father) and the earth (mother).
 3. An evil garment (*lbūšā bīšā*).
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SECTION 10: GRAMMATICAL SUMMARY

THE PRONOMINAL SUFFIXES (ATTACH TO NOUNS AND PREPOSITIONS)

SUFFIX	MEANING	EXAMPLE (BAYT- HOUSE)	EXAMPLE (L- TO)
-y	my	baytī (my house)	lī (to me)
-k	your (m)	baytāk (your house)	lāk (to you)
-ky	your (f)	baytēky (your house)	lēky (to you)
-eh	his	bayteh (his house)	lēh (to him)
-āh	her	baytāh (her house)	lāh (to her)
-an	our	baytan (our house)	lān (to us)
-kūn	your (pl)	baytkūn (your house)	lkūn (to you all)
-hūn	their (pl)	baythūn (their house)	lhūn (to them)

SAYING “TO HAVE” (Possession Formula)

FORMULA	SYRIAC	MEANING
ĪT + L- + Suffix	īt lī / itly	I have (There is to me)
LAYT + L- + Suffix	layt lēh	He does not have
ĪT + L- + Suffix	īt lhūn malkā	They have a king

SECTION 11: ADDITIONAL VOCABULARY

The following high-frequency words round out this lesson's vocabulary to 30 terms.

SYRIAC (ESTRANGELA)	TRANSLITERATION	PART OF SPEECH	MEANING	NOTES
ܩܪܝܬܐ	qṛītā	f. noun	village	emphatic state
ܠܫܢܐ	leššānā	m. noun	tongue, language	
ܟܕܝܐ	garmā	m. noun	bone	
ܟܦܐ	kēpā	f. noun	stone, rock	
ܡܝܐ	mayyā	m. noun (pl.)	water	plural in form
ܢܘܢܐ	nūnā	m. noun	fish	
ܡܕܝܬܐ	mdittā	f. noun	city	
ܫܡܫܐ	šemšā	m. noun	sun	
ܬܪܝܐ	tar'ā	m. noun	door, gate	
ܡܫܗܐ	mešhā	m. noun	oil	
ܫܠܐ	ḥaylā	m. noun	power, army	
ܐܕܢܐ	'ednā	f. noun	ear	
ܩܝܣܐ	qaysā	m. noun	wood, tree	
ܢܗܪܐ	nahrā	m. noun	river	
ܫܒܪܐ	sabrā	m. noun	hope	
ܕܗܠܬܐ	dehltā	f. noun	fear, religion	abstract noun
ܫܗܪܐ	sahrā	m. noun	moon	
ܪܓܠܐ	reglā	f. noun	foot	
ܫܠܡܐ	šlāmā	m. noun	peace	common greeting
ܐܬܪܐ	'atrā	m. noun	place, country	
ܫܗܕܐ	sāhdā	m. noun	witness, martyr	
ܒܫܪܐ	besrā	m. noun	flesh	
ܬܝܒܘܬܐ	ṭaybūttā	f. noun	grace	

SYRIAC (ESTRANGELA)	TRANSLITERATION	PART OF SPEECH	MEANING	NOTES
ܬܐܪܐ	tawrā	m. noun	bull, ox	
ܩܝܡܐ	qyāmā	m. noun	covenant	
ܠܘܪܗܐ	’ūrḥā	f. noun	way, road	
ܚܝܠܐ	hayklā	m. noun	temple, palace	
ܥܝܢܐ	‘aynā	f. noun	eye	
ܦܡܐ	pūmā	m. noun	mouth	
ܕܝܢܐ	dīnā	m. noun	judgment	
ܫܦܬܐ	sputā	f. noun	lip	emphatic state
ܬܠܓܓܐ	talggā	m. noun	ridge, back	
ܫܝܪܐ	širē	f. noun	side, rib	
ܓܢܒܐ	ganbā	m. noun	thigh	
ܕܪܐܥܐ	dar ‘ā	f. noun	arm	
ܥܓܓܐܠܐ	‘aggālā	m. noun	calf (leg part)	
ܚܬܢܐ	ḥatnā	m. noun	bridegroom	
ܚܠܬܐ	kaltā	f. noun	bride	
ܐܡܡܘܪܐ	‘ammūrā	m. noun	uncle (paternal)	
ܐܡܡܬܐ	‘ammtā	f. noun	aunt (paternal)	
ܐܡܡܩܐ	‘ammqā	m. adj	deep	
ܦܠܬܐ	paltā	m. noun	escape, safety	
ܐܬܬܝܪܐ	‘attirā	m. adj	rich, mighty	
ܡܝܫܟܢܐ	meskennā	m. adj	poor, humble	
ܓܝܒܒܐܪܐ	gibbōrā	m. adj	mighty, strong	
ܩܠܝܠܐ	qallilā	m. adj	small, few	
ܝܚܕܐ	yḥiddā	m. adj	alone, unique	
ܕܠܐ	‘addālā	m. adj	just, righteous	